

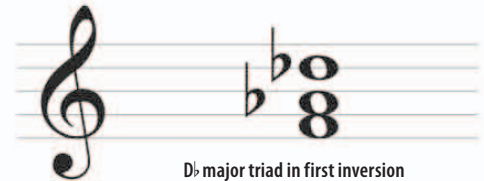
Inversions of a seventh chord

Seventh chords have four different notes—the root, third, fifth, and seventh—and can thus have three different inversions. As with triads, the seventh chord is in first inversion if its third is the bass note, and in second inversion if its fifth is the bass note. However, it can also be in third inversion, with its seventh as the bass note.

△ Root The example above shows a C major seventh chord in root position.	△ First inversion The same chord is shown here in first inversion, with the third (E) as its bass note.	△ Second inversion In second inversion, the C major seventh chord has the fifth (G) as its bass note.	△ Third inversion In third inversion, the C major seventh chord has the seventh (B) as its bass note.
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Neapolitan sixth

The Neapolitan chord is a major triad built on the note a minor second above the tonic. For example, if the music is in C major, D $\flat$ is a minor second above the tonic, so the Neapolitan chord is a D $\flat$ major triad. Neapolitan chords are usually found in first inversion, so they are called Neapolitan sixths because their top note is a minor sixth above their bass note.



Neapolitan 6th in C major

In C major, the Neapolitan chord is a D $\flat$ major triad, and the Neapolitan sixth is D $\flat$ major in first inversion.

C major

Minor 2nd above tonic = D $\flat$

D $\flat$ major triad = Neapolitan chord

Interval = minor 6th

In first inversion = Neapolitan sixth

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The Neapolitan sixth is called “Neapolitan” because it is particularly associated with the 18th-century composers of Italian opera who were active in and around the city of Naples, such as Giovanni Battista Pergolesi, Giovanni Paisiello, Domenico Cimarosa, and Alessandro Scarlatti. These composers used the Neapolitan sixth to create emotional and dramatic tension in their music.



The **dominant seventh** is the most **common seventh chord** because it naturally **resolves onto the tonic**.

